

Chapter 33: Names You Don't Forget

Jenny told herself not to think about it.

That was her first mistake.

Because the more she tried not to think about Victoria, the more the name stayed.

Like it had taken up space behind her thoughts and refused to leave.

She hated that.

She hated even more that Austin had said it so casually.

Victoria.

Like she belonged in his vocabulary.

Like she had always been there.

The restaurant was quieter than usual in the morning.

Jenny cleaned tables she had already cleaned.

Twice.

Bao noticed immediately.

"You're doing that thing again."

"I'm cleaning."

"You're thinking."

"I'm working."

"You're thinking about her."

Jenny stopped wiping the table.

Slowly.

Then looked at him.

"Stop talking."

Bao raised his hands.

"I'm just saying."

Jenny turned away.

But the silence that followed only made it worse.

Because he was right.

At noon, Austin arrived alone.

No Victoria.

No explanation.

Just him.

Jenny noticed the absence immediately.

Which annoyed her.

Because she didn't want to notice anything.

He walked in like nothing had changed.

But Jenny could feel it anyway.

Something had changed.

He didn't sit.

He went straight to the counter.

"Hello," he said.

Simple.

Neutral.

But his eyes lingered on her a little longer than usual.

Jenny didn't return the warmth.

"Table seven is open."

"I'm not sitting."

Of course not.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"You're not here long?"

"I am."

That made her pause.

"...You are?"

"Yes."

A beat.

Then she asked carefully,

"Where is she?"

Austin looked at her.

"You're asking."

Jenny immediately regretted it.

"I'm just—"

"Curious," he finished.

She didn't answer.

Austin didn't push.

Instead, he said quietly,

"She left this morning."

Jenny nodded.

"Okay."

But the silence between them stretched.

And she hated that it felt heavier than when Victoria was here.

Austin studied her for a moment.

"You didn't like her."

It wasn't a question.

Jenny shrugged.

"I don't know her."

"That's not what I asked."

She exhaled sharply.

"You brought her here."

"Yes."

That honesty again.

Always direct.

Jenny frowned.

"Why?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"She needed something from me."

Jenny narrowed her eyes.

"And did she get it?"

A pause.

"Yes."

That answer landed wrong.

Too clean.

Too final.

Jenny felt something tighten in her chest.

"What kind of 'something'?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then said quietly,

"Closure."

That word made her stop.

"...Closure?"

"Yes."

Jenny crossed her arms tighter.

"For what?"

Austin hesitated for the first time that day.

Then—

"For what we used to be."

Silence.

That shifted everything.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

But enough.

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

Austin leaned slightly against the counter.

"You're quieter today."

"I'm working."

"You always say that when you're avoiding something."

Jenny shot him a look.

"I'm not avoiding anything."

A pause.

Then—

"You are avoiding asking what you want to know."

That hit too close.

Jenny stiffened.

"I don't want to know anything."

Austin didn't respond immediately.

Then softly—

"That's not true."

She turned fully toward him.

"Why are you always like this?"

"Like what?"

"Like you already know what I'm thinking."

"I don't know," he corrected.

"I pay attention."

Jenny shook her head.

"That's worse."

A faint pause.

Then almost gently—

"No," he said. "It's honesty."

Jenny looked down at the counter.

For a moment, she didn't speak.

Then quietly—

"She said I was important to you."

Austin didn't react immediately.

But something in his posture changed.

Subtle.

Still controlled.

But different.

"Yes," he said.

That simple confirmation made her chest tighten.

Jenny frowned.

"...Why would she say that?"

Austin looked at her.

"Because it's true."

Silence.

The restaurant felt too still again.

Jenny exhaled.

"You don't just say things like that."

"I do," he said.

"When they are real."

Jenny looked away.

Of course she did.

But this time...

It didn't feel like avoidance.

It felt like pressure.

Austin stood straighter.

"I should go."

Jenny nodded quickly.

"Okay."

But he didn't leave immediately.

Instead, he looked at her one more time.

Longer than usual.

Then said quietly,

"She doesn't change anything."

Jenny hesitated.

"...I didn't say she did."

"I know," he replied.

A pause.

Then softer—

“But I wanted you to hear it anyway.”

And then he left.

Jenny stood alone behind the counter.

The words stayed longer than he did.

She doesn't change anything.

But nothing about the day felt unchanged anymore.

Because now...

She knew there was a past in his life that had real weight.

And worse than that...

She knew she had started caring about what that past meant.

Even when she didn't want to.